

PART TWO

Managing Yourself



5.

Becoming a Person of Influence

Do your colleagues listen when you suggest a new idea? Do they seek out your opinion? Does your boss respect your recommendations and take you seriously when you argue for a new approach? Do people in other areas of the business know you and respond well to your work with them? In other words, are you a person of influence in your organization?

In chapter 2, “Building Trust and Credibility,” we discussed the importance of establishing your employees’ confidence in you as their manager. That foundation is essential to be seen as a strong leader, one that others want to follow. The next step is to use that trust to execute your vision and drive business success in the organization at large.

Influence, as we’ll use the term, represents your ability to persuade others and have a positive impact on your organization’s decisions, plans, and results. Success in your role as a leader means trying new approaches and strategies. To do this, you need to convince others in your company to follow—and to endorse—your ideas. You also need to be able to advocate

effectively for your team, in order to both keep their trust and also enhance the work that they can do for the good of the organization.

You might think that purposefully pursuing influence is distasteful, and surely you don't want to be seen as scheming and manipulating people to always get your way. But influence really isn't about getting "your" way. It's about helping to create positive and productive outcomes for your organization, with and through others.

To do this, first you need to understand the basis of your power; then you can wield it to better work with peers, collaborate across silos in your organization, influence your boss, and promote your ideas.

Positional versus personal power

Influence is a combination of two kinds of power. Your role as a manager automatically gives you *positional power* in your organization—power that comes from your job description and title, like the ability to hire and fire people or approve a budget. In earlier generations, corporate cultures put a greater emphasis on a manager's positional power, and there was an expectation that if you told direct reports to do something, they'd do it without question. But as hierarchies are giving way to flatter organizations and looser networks of collaboration, you can't rely on just your job title to get things done. As a manager, you need to work *through* other people—your direct reports, who can execute your vision; your peers, who can support it laterally; and your management team, who can make or break it from above. Getting their buy-in requires a different approach.

To exercise influence up and down the chain of command, you need to also draw effectively on your *personal power* by cultivating social capital. Relationships, reputation, reciprocity, institutional knowledge, and informal know-how—social capital represents all of the trust, value, and goodwill you've created in your organization. For example, when you increase the organization's profits or help your team secure good year-end bonuses, you create economic value for your higher-ups and direct reports alike. Down the line, when you want their buy-in for a new initiative, they'll be more likely to accept your plan and throw their weight

behind your leadership. Your past success has both generated goodwill and earned respect.

If you maintain a strong network of connections in the organization and you support initiatives that are important to others, you will be seen as a valuable ally. You can gain social capital over time by cultivating a few key habits, according to leadership coach Lisa Lai:

Take action and solve problems.

Find and solve real problems for the organization, and for your direct reports, peers, and supervisors. Identify opportunities to become better, smarter, and faster. Suggest specific changes that could be positive for employees, customers, or partners.

Signs that you need to work on this behavior include:

- You tend to ignore problems until they either go away or become the norm.
- You think more about coping mechanisms than solutions.
- You struggle with turning complaints into to-do lists.

Be a team player.

Embrace change and try to deliver the best possible results, even if the decision isn't one you'd choose. Work hard when no one's watching.

Signs that you need to work on this behavior include:

- When someone suggests a new way of doing things, your predominant reaction is fear or annoyance.
- You don't feel ownership of an outcome when you've objected to the process that produced it.

Have informed opinions.

Develop a deep, comprehensive understanding of your business and of your company's power structure. Listen as much as you talk. Provide constructive input when you have an opinion.

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Warning signs that you're struggling with this behavior include:

- You don't contribute in the moment because you're not sure what you think.
- You beat yourself up afterward for being quiet, or you blame others for talking over you.
- You change your mind frequently.

Help other people succeed.

Support your boss and acknowledge their authority. Support and respect your peers, even when you disagree. Offer opportunities to other people. Avoid bad-mouthing the company, leadership, and customers.

Warning signs that you're struggling with this behavior include:

- You withhold information and opportunities from others in the organization.
- You prioritize making yourself look good over promoting the successes of your colleagues.
- You're indifferent to other people's career trajectories because you don't think they affect you very much.

Respect others.

Treat your coworkers with respect. Be direct and honest, and take direction easily. Learn to work well with others, including people you don't really like. Manage conflict productively, without undue negativity.

Warning signs that you're struggling with this behavior include:

- You have a history of enemies and rivals in the office.
- You tend to hold grudges.
- You disrespect or disregard people's professional abilities if you don't like them.

Demonstrate integrity.

Share what you can with others without breaking confidences. Avoid barking or biting unless you have to, and use positional power only when it matters. Don't let others bully you, and stand up for what you believe is right.

Warning signs that you have work to do in this area include:

- You share other people's personal information even when you know you shouldn't.
- You lose your temper and make threats to people under your authority.
- You let other people talk you into doing things you don't want to do.

These strategies help you strengthen your relationships and build your social capital, all to the benefit of your ability to influence others.

Managing up

Whether you're asking for a raise, securing more resources for your team, or developing a new strategy for your group, you need to garner influence with your managers in particular. They are a key figure in your professional life, with the ability to open opportunities, connect you and your team with useful resources and relationships, offer you advice, and advocate for you and your team in higher levels of the organization. If you can't influence them, you'll be frustrated at best and professionally sidelined at worst.

When you exercise this influence, you're reversing the traditional power flow in the relationship. That's "managing up"—that is, making a conscious effort to affect the perceptions, opinions, and decisions of your managers. To do this effectively, you need to understand your managers' motivations and their hot buttons, set commonly understood expectations for your performance, and adapt yourself to their way of working.

Put yourself in your boss's shoes

Think about what professional life looks like from your manager's perspective. What are their performance targets, and what professional trajectory are they on? What other motivations play into their decisions? What are the major pain points in their job right now?

Some of these questions you can ask about directly, but others you're going to have to figure out by observation. Pay attention to what stresses them out, what pushes them into overdrive, what tasks they're most likely to micromanage.

Understanding what your boss is incentivized to accomplish can help you make sure your ideas are generally aligned with their needs. And you'll be able to position your ideas in a way that highlights the value to your boss as well as the organization.

Discuss expectations

To become a person of influence with your manager, you need to know what they expect from you and how you will work together, and what you can do to make sure those interactions work smoothly. You may have gathered some information on the listening tour you conducted when you entered the job (see chapter 4, "Positioning Yourself for Success"). But if you haven't discussed strategic outlook and expectations with your boss, now is a good time. Ask questions like:

- "What are your major objectives right now within the organization? How can I support them?"
- "How do you prefer to communicate with the people you manage? How would you like me to share information or updates with you? What's a good way for me to bring questions or problems to you when they arise?"
- "In the past, when you've worked really well with a direct report, what do you think made that relationship so successful? What behaviors or habits are really important to you in the people you manage?"

Thinking about your boss's other relationships is also helpful. Understand who their allies (and rivals) are. Watch their interactions with others. What kinds of people do they get along with best? What work habits annoy them the most? What is the best way to earn and maintain their trust over time? Knowledge is most definitely power in this situation, so be honest with yourself about how they're likely to perceive you. The more you understand, the better you can align with them.

Gathering this information will help you meet their expectations for your performance more successfully. But you may also need to manage their expectations if they're unreasonable or if they actively interfere with your ability to deliver results. If you need to challenge their demands, prepare for a conversation by thinking through:

- What specific expectations do you want to negotiate? How can you link the changes you care about (for example, moving a deadline) with something else *they* will value highly (for example, expanding the scope of the work or meeting a higher-quality measure)?
- How will you link your proposal to your supervisor's goals and show that you put those goals first? To communicate your honesty and sincerity here, use the trust-building strategies that you already know they respond to best, like asking for feedback about how your proposal could better serve their needs.

Adapt yourself to your boss's work style

You'll be better positioned to influence your boss on the important points when you make your daily interactions as frictionless as possible. Tailor your work style to theirs: do they prefer short or long conversations? Do they like to get in early on the decision-making process or review a final recommendation? What kind of evidence do they find compelling? How much time and attention are they prepared to provide on a given day? What particular expertise or skills do they rely on you for? What idiosyncratic preferences do they have about how office life should proceed—for example, how to run a meeting, write an email, or arrange a workspace? Be proactive in making whatever accommodations you can.

In order to partner with and influence your managers, you need to understand and adapt to them in a way that makes your working relationship positive and productive. And doing so will also increase your influence in the wider organization.

Partnering with your peers

To get your job done, you depend upon many people over whom you have no authority. These relationships are exemplars of the principle outlined earlier—that influence is founded in your personal power rather than organizational hierarchy. Collaborating with those who work outside your chain of command is vital to your success, requiring you to actively achieve trust, credibility, and alignment.

Making this more difficult, in many cases your colleagues' priorities will be fundamentally different from yours. Your goals may not be aligned and, in some cases, they will be diametrically opposed: you want to create a new product that could threaten the success of one of their best sellers, for example.

Here's how you can become a person of influence with your peers throughout the organization:

Foster a network inside your organization

Many managers shy away from formally cultivating a network because it smacks of politicking and self-promotion. But, as Harvard Business School professor Linda Hill and coauthor Kent Lineback write in their book *Being the Boss*, "If you don't engage the organization and exercise influence effectively, if you hold yourself above the political push-and-pull, you will limit your effectiveness as a manager."

These robust professional ties support collaboration in a few ways. First, they let you obtain and provide information more easily; you can get a better understanding of what else is going on in your department or ask for feedback on a new idea. A network can also help you better connect your group to the rest of your organization by trading resources or shar-

ing expertise. And they also allow you to form coalitions around shared goals.

To create this kind of network, seek out people with whom you have a rapport and who are genuinely invested in your development. Cultivate ongoing partnerships in which you have a reliable stream of give-and-take. These are stable relationships with a lot of overlap and history that won't wilt under the first favor asked.

By creating these connections before you need them, you will be in a much better position to influence positive outcomes with and through others in your network. If you believe you can't afford to invest the time to build your network, consider this: you can't afford *not* to invest the time.

Make your enemies your allies

Do any of these people sound familiar? The rival who got passed over when you were promoted. The insecure colleague who needs to be right about *everything*. The coworker who openly disdains your personal style. Your first thought might be to avoid these people and the conflict they represent. Whether someone just rubs you the wrong way, or whether you have genuinely competing and divergent interests, it's possible to defuse the negativity and reorient the relationship around shared goals and interests. Initiate a one-on-one meeting—maybe afternoon coffee or lunch at their favorite spot—and follow these steps.

1. **Redirect.** Help your colleague channel their negative emotions away from you by focusing on what you *do* have in common. For example: "It sounds like we've had similar experiences getting used to this new role. I really admire how you handled the transition." With some people, you can be honest about the source of tension and recast the problem between you in a favorable light: "I know it might seem like we're supposed to be rivals, but I think it's great that we have the same skill set and totally different perspectives. You're the only person here I can talk to about X topic and trust I'll get an honest, smart response."

2. **Reciprocate.** Give before you ask. Show them you're willing to give up something of value that's also concrete and immediately actionable. If you make a promise of future support, find a tangible action you can take *now* to make good on that commitment. This reinforces that you want to establish an ongoing relationship rather than just ask for a favor.
3. **Reason.** Make a clear, plausible suggestion of how you think you two could work together to support each others' and the organization's success. What are your expectations for a relationship, and why do they make sense for your colleague, too? End by presenting them with a decision point: Will they commit to this pact now? Consider putting an end date on your offer so that your coworker understands that this new relationship, with its attendant benefits, is something they need to be committed to. An easy way to do this is to say that if you don't hear back from them in a certain number of days, you'll assume they aren't interested. This will create a sense of urgency or importance associated with the discussion, without demand or pressure.

Bringing your allies on board, never mind your enemies, requires energy and tact. But it's worth it; after all, you're not doing this just to make friends and amass power (although both may happen as a result). The influence you develop in your relationships with peers will make all the difference as you work to extend your leadership outside your unit, to shape the way your entire organization works together. The most successful and upwardly mobile leaders have strong, collaborative, respectful relationships with their peers.

Silo busting and effectiveness

Working effectively with colleagues in *other* units is also critical: it can help you get the resources and buy-in you need to do your job, deliver better results, and influence your organization's overall direction. It can also make your organization as a whole more effective—if you collaborate on

a new product, rather than duplicating efforts, for example, or if you take on an initiative to standardize a process across the company. This is where your efforts to build trust and credibility really begin to pay off for you as a leader.

Managing these collaborations can be challenging, however, especially if you work in a company with units or systems that operate in isolation from one another. Your peers don't necessarily know you, so you haven't had the opportunity to earn their trust. What's more, their business cultures, priorities, goals, and incentives probably differ from yours. To align your efforts:

Identify key players.

If you're tasked with collaborating with people in a different unit, take some time to understand them and who *their* stakeholders are. How are they perceived in the organization? Who else has relevant positional power? Who has personal power with or over the people you're ultimately trying to persuade? What are the personality issues in play? Who is likely to undermine your efforts if they feel you're encroaching on their unit's territory? Don't be afraid of including the latter group in your conversations; they'll cause you more trouble off the team than on it. Be willing to acknowledge other people of influence in the organization and join forces.

Understand their incentives.

Make sure the motivations of this team are aligned with the change you're trying to make. Learn about the performance goals of team members from other groups and look for areas where there are likely to be conflicts with the initiative you are proposing. Consider how you will mitigate them. Are there other incentives you can invoke? Material help or information for one of their projects? Intangibles like status, respect, or pride? Visibility and involvement in strategic initiatives can have a persuasive effect.

Carve out time to collaborate.

Formalize your initiative by creating a team with a defined membership and mission: "I'm inviting all the engineering and HR managers together

so we can talk about a problem we're all facing—how to improve diversity in our workforce.” If you're collaborating with people outside your chain of command, keep the meetings casual and under the radar or look for an ally higher up who will sanction your work. In either case, let people know that you value their input and look forward to collaborating with them on the initiative.

Adopt a negotiator's mindset.

The individuals on your cross-unit team may not share the same goals, but you surely have some common ground. Focus on interests rather than positions: What's most important to your opponents? Don't get hung up on what you *can't* do for them; think creatively about what you *can* do that they might value. What value do they bring to the table? What good ideas do they have that you never considered?

Avoid using positional power in these situations unless absolutely necessary. Personal power can be much more influential in terms of securing interest and collaboration from others.

Promoting your ideas to others

We've talked about how to garner and leverage personal power to become a person of influence in your organization. As with the mechanics of influence, which depend on understanding your audience's point of view, the same principles of persuasion apply when you want to argue for a specific idea, plan, or business case.

The first step: determine whether an appeal to your audience's *hearts* or their *minds* will be more effective. “Heart” here means their emotional center, the hopes, fears, and memories that shape their attitudes. An appeal to people's minds, on the other hand, speaks directly to their reasoning power. While hearts and minds are both important targets for persuasion, it's better to use one or the other to frame your initial discussion. You'll be most persuasive if you tailor your case as narrowly as you can to your audi-

ence by making a calculation about whether logic or emotion is going to be most effective.

Focus on two questions. First, *how personal is the issue at hand to your audience?* If you're broaching a topic that's tied up in their identity or their vested interests, you should be prepared for a strong emotional response that even they might not understand. You'll need to work through, or at least disarm, this reaction to bring them around to your point of view, so come ready to address their hearts. On the other hand, if they don't have much at stake in the decision or if they're good at keeping their egos in check, they'll likely respond well to straight reasoning.

Second, *where are you in the decision-making process?* If you're at an active decision point and you're trying to win votes, lean hard on logic. If you're trying to solicit interest early on or get buy-in after the fact, emotions are a better target.

As you make your assessment, avoid sweeping generalizations about gender or function. Don't follow persistent biases; for example, that women are more emotional than men, or that finance people only respond to cold, hard facts.

For some more specific scenarios, see exhibit 5-1.

Once you know whether you're targeting your audience's hearts or minds, you can tailor your argument accordingly.

EXHIBIT 5-1

Winning employees' hearts or minds

Win hearts when . . .

- You're introducing a new idea and trying to pique interest.
- You want to raise the bar on performance or commitment.
- You're leading a team that is struggling with discord or conflict.
- You're presenting something that's disruptive to the listener's sense of self.
- You're talking to people who are in a heightened emotional state.
- You need to gain support for a decision that's already been made.

Win minds when . . .

- You're talking to people who won't feel personally implicated by what you have to say.
- You're presenting a correction to the facts underlying a decision.
- You need to address a highly complex or technical set of problems.
- You want to help an overwhelmed team stop overanalyzing and see a situation clearly.
- You're trying to change direction on something previously decided.

Winning hearts

To draw out your audience's emotional response in service of your argument:

Make it personal.

Your argument needs a “hook”—an opening idea that goes right to the heart of what your listeners care about. What's in it for them? What frustrations will your proposal remove, what excitements will it draw on? Address people directly, and when you talk about the overall benefits for the organization, tailor your pitch to the things that matter most to them. For example: “I know we're all worried about job security as our company looks for a buyer. The initiative I'm proposing will make our whole unit more valuable to the organization—and to any buyer.”

Speak explicitly to a big emotion.

Fear, anger, betrayal, pride, ambition, joy—these feelings come from an intensely personal place. If your listeners are resisting change because they're afraid of trying something new, validate that emotion and then disarm it: “Changing how we do this will be scary, because we'll all have to learn something new and risk failure. But we're all in the same boat here: we can learn together and support each other while we make mistakes.”

Tell a story.

Stories bring your ideas alive. They grab your audience's attention with riveting plots and characters that individual listeners can relate to, evoking powerful emotions. They also simplify complex ideas. Think about Aesop's fable “The Boy Who Cried Wolf.” The moral of that story is a fairly subtle idea about the costs of lying, not that it's bad or that it doesn't work, but that it harms us down the line when others learn to disbelieve even our truths. But everyone who hears that story intuitively and emotionally knows what it means. Good stories stay in our minds because they force us to draw out the meaning for ourselves.

Use metaphors and analogies.

Metaphors represent overarching worldviews that shape people's everyday perceptions and actions, such as "Business is war." Analogies are comparisons that include the words "like" or "as": "Finishing this project was like climbing a mountain in a snowstorm." You can use both of these rhetorical tools to give people a new, vivid way of thinking about a familiar idea. A good metaphor or analogy strikes like lightning, illuminating your point of view without overexplaining or belaboring your point.

Winning minds

If you've chosen a strategy that focuses on the logic of the argument, try these tactics:

Present compelling evidence.

Variety is impressive, but you want to focus on the kinds of proof that your audience is most likely to care about. Listeners who care about expert endorsements will like *testimonials*, while *statistics* will work on audiences who work with numbers or who want to quantify the big picture. *Data visuals* can be very powerful with wide audiences—slides, flip charts, video clips, or product samples.

Ask striking questions.

Questions stimulate your listeners' attention and invite them to contribute—in a controlled way—to the point you're making. *Disturbing questions* focus their attention on their most pressing problems ("How many sales did we lose to last week's software malfunction?"), while *leading questions* influence how your listeners interpret facts and what they remember ("Don't you think our competitors would do X if given the chance?"). And *rhetorical questions* press the listener to accept a proposition that you've formulated ("Are you willing to risk that we'll look so unprofessional again?").

Deciding whether to tap into hearts or minds is easy when you're presenting your idea to an individual or a small, like-minded group. The bigger challenge comes when you're trying to persuade a group with diverse perspectives. Then your best bet is to briefly discuss the problem you're trying to solve and how your solution helps the business, your employees, or your customers. Next, cater messaging to different perspectives in the room. For example, appeal to both minds—"If you're wondering why this problem is compelling, let me share the data with you"—and hearts—"And for those of you who are wondering what this means for our employees, let me tell you a story about how it affects Fatma in marketing." You've appealed to hearts.

Whatever approach you take, the more thoughtful you are at the beginning of this process, the more effective you'll be.

Much of your ability to influence others is driven by your understanding of their different perspectives and your willingness to reach out to them. Whether you are presenting a proposal to the board of directors, trying to convince your boss to take you seriously, or working with peers in your group or across the organization, think about how your actions will make other people feel, and assess what problems you can solve for them. This approach to becoming a person of influence in your organization can result in relationships that are positive, productive, and permanent.

Recap

- Influence is a combination of two kinds of power, *positional* (having to do with your title) and *personal* (having to do with your social capital).
- You need to manage up because your boss is a key figure in your professional life. They can open opportunities and advocate for you, but without their support, you will be frustrated.

- To become a person of influence with your peers around the organization, foster a network that can help you obtain information, share expertise, and form coalitions.
- Working with colleagues across silos can be particularly challenging because their cultures and priorities may be different from yours.
- To promote a specific idea to others, consider their point of view.

Action items

Foster your cultural capital by:

- ☐ Solving a small problem for someone else. Follow up on a specific issue that is plaguing a direct report on a daily basis. Take a task off your boss's plate.
- ☐ Learning something new about your company. Ask a peer to explain a new technical point. Talk to someone who's been at your organization longer than you about how your unit has evolved.
- ☐ Offering someone an opportunity. Ask a team member or peer to kick off a team meeting or ask a subject-matter expert to educate your team.
- ☐ Providing support to a peer. Explore how you can support an initiative that matters to one of your peers and fosters business success. Find a way to help.
- ☐ Invest time in outreach to build and extend your network of peers. Request small amounts of time with peers you have an opportunity to learn from, share information with, or partner with to achieve business outcomes. Use a specific opportunity as your reason for reaching out and making the connection.

In situations in which you need to manage up:

- ☐ Put yourself in your boss's shoes. Consider the goals and pressures that motivate their professional lives and how you can help them succeed.

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- ☐ Clarify their expectations. Through conversation and observation, figure out what kind of working relationship they want with you. Negotiate problematic expectations by showing how the changes you seek will benefit *them*.
- ☐ Adapt yourself to their work styles. Make your daily interactions as smooth as possible by accommodating habits like their communication style or decision-making process.

In situations in which you need to persuade, evaluate in advance of a discussion whether you'll be most successful appealing to your audience's emotional center or their rational side:

- ☐ To win hearts, make your argument personal and have it speak to the emotion of the situation. Tell a story and employ metaphors and analogies.
- ☐ To win minds, present compelling evidence and push your audience to engage with it by posing incisive questions. Appeal to the logic that supports your case.



6.

Communicating Effectively

To succeed as a manager in today's frenetic business environment, you need to be able to capture and keep people's attention. Whether you're speaking informally with your team, presenting to a group of your colleagues, writing an email or report, or leading a meeting, your ideas are constantly competing for your listeners' and readers' focus. One moment they're following your analysis of third-quarter financials and the next they're thinking about an email they have to respond to, or their child's head cold.

When we're on the receiving end of communications, we crave compelling, concrete, simple doses of information with an authentic voice. Creating this kind of communication requires careful planning and preparation, whether for writing or speaking, in a memo, presentation, or meeting.

Finding your voice as a leader

We're accustomed to thinking that great communicators have a special kind of charisma, a way of holding themselves or of writing that makes

them sound authoritative. John Antonakis, Marika Fenley, and Sue Liechti, researchers at the University of Lausanne, studied charisma in dozens of business leaders and found several physical and rhetorical tactics that were universally effective—so effective that in one study, they resulted in a 60 percent improvement in how observers rated leaders' competence.

But charisma isn't a magic trait that some people have and some people don't. Becoming a masterful communicator is possible for anyone who learns the set of behaviors these researchers identified:

- **Animated voice.** Monotone voices sound apathetic, so vary the volume of your voice when you speak. Use your voice to express emotion and pace yourself. Use pauses to create drama and convey a sense of control over your environment.
- **Facial expressions.** Make eye contact, and let listeners see as well as hear your passion. You don't want *every* emotional reaction to be transparent (for example, it's rarely a good idea to show anger), but smiles and frowns, concern and amusement, all communicate your humanity.
- **Gestures.** Your body language can emphasize a point. For example, clasp your hands to illustrate "working together," "integration," or "solidarity." Or let your palms fall open to demonstrate "opening doors," "transparency," and so on. You can experiment with your own vocabulary of gestures by practicing your presentations in front of a mirror.
- **Expressions of moral conviction or shared sentiment.** Affirming shared beliefs and experiences can be highly motivating, as sociologists have long known. When you reflect back to your group members their own values or ideas, you activate these primal feelings of solidarity and excitement. Build around points of connection.
- **Contrasts.** These are easy to learn and use: some variation of "Not this—but that," or "On the one hand—on the other hand." The form generates drama naturally and is pleasing to our brains, which like dualities.

- **Three-part lists.** Three is, indeed, the magic number: it shows a pattern, gives an impression of completeness, and is easy to remember. Use this technique when you're at the dramatic high point of a comment, especially a call to action.

But for these techniques to work, you also need to integrate them into your natural presentation. A robotic sequence of gestures and three-part lists will fall flat unless they're infused with your own verbal style and physical habits, not to mention your own values and experiences. Especially when you present to an audience that already knows you—your team, for example—remember that the figure you strike “on stage” needs to gel with the leader they know from the break room. To bring your self-presentation into closer alignment, ask yourself:

- In what situations do you feel most comfortable communicating? How can you adapt the tactics you use in that setting more broadly to other settings?
- What authentic parts of yourself are you struggling to express at work right now? For example, maybe you *feel* passionate and assertive about your work, but you don't come across that way in meetings. How could one of these tactics help you convey that part of yourself more clearly?

Practice using the tactics outlined here until you find what feels most comfortable to you and allows you to feel natural and most compelling in front of others.

As a new leader, you may not feel that you've found your authentic voice just yet. But as you work on understanding what matters to you as a leader and how you want to present yourself in the presence of others, you'll start to develop your own voice to communicate and influence others.

Mastering the written word

Many people you work with may know you almost entirely through your writing, from emails, reports, proposals, and presentations to texts, IMs,

and social media posts. Yet, with this form of communication, you have limited tools to capture and keep others' attention: you can't lean forward or gesture to emphasize a point. That's why good writing isn't just about grammar and usage, but structure, clarity, and voice. You don't need to be a professional writer to achieve this effect; instead, take the following steps as you compose and refine your words.

Step 1: Prepare

Before you begin writing, you need to know what you're trying to say. Are you arguing for a particular idea or point of view? Are you providing background context for a discussion? Are you documenting an internal process? In the *HBR Guide to Better Business Writing*, writing and usage expert Bryan A. Garner recommends writing out your three main points as full sentences, spelling out your logic as clearly as you can. That way, when you begin to write, you already know the ideas you want to convey and the supporting points you'll make.

Begin thinking about your audience as well at this early stage in the process. What do they already know about your topic, and what questions will they have? Is your audience internal or external? Will they be opposed to or aligned with your ideas? Will they want just the headlines, a detailed outline, or both? Pick an organizing principle that will make your idea as accessible as possible to your reader. (See exhibit 6-1.)

Once you've chosen an organizing principle, create an outline that places your ideas and supporting points in order. This may feel like overkill for, say, a simple email. But the more you practice this process, the more you'll realize that even the shortest written communication benefits from preparation and a structured approach.

Step 2: Write your first draft

You don't need to start writing at the beginning of your outline. Begin writing the section or material you feel most comfortable with, keeping your outline in front of you. When you've finished that, choose the next item you're comfortable writing, and so on. Stop periodically to compare your draft to your plan. Many writers save the introductory material until the

EXHIBIT 6-1

Organizing methods for writing

If you're writing:	Consider using this organizing method:	By:
Feasibility studies, re-search results, and planning reports	Compare and contrast	Evaluating the advantages and disadvantages of two possibilities
Any type of internal document intended for particularly busy readers	Order of importance	Putting the most critical information at the beginning of your document
A document that traces a series of events	Chronological	Listing events in the order in which they occurred
Instructions or user manuals	Process and procedure	Describing who does what and when
Trip reports, descriptions of machinery, and research reports	Spatial arrangement	Describing one aspect of your topic at a time
Work orders, training materials, and customer service letters	Specific to general, or general to specific	Starting with a specific or general concept your readers are already familiar with and then moving to a specific or general concept that's new to them
Technical reports, annual reports, and financial analyses	Analytical	Formulating a hypothesis and testing it through questioning

Source: Adapted from "Writing Skills" in *Harvard ManageMentor*. Boston: Harvard Business School Publishing, 2016. Electronic.

end; it's often easier to compose an engaging and effective opening paragraph once you know what your conclusions are.

Garner suggests writing your first draft as quickly as possible. "Your sentences will be shorter than they otherwise would be," he says. "Your idioms will be more natural, and your draft should start taking shape before you know it. If there's a painful part of writing, it's doing the first draft. When you shorten the duration, it's not as painful."

Step 3: Edit your draft

Once the draft is complete, set it aside for as long as you can. Getting some distance will help you spot places where you've overplotted your argument, gone off-message, or let your voice falter.

When you dive back in, review your draft to see whether you've set forth your ideas in a logical, focused, and clear manner. Have you stated your main message clearly? Have you articulated any action items clearly? Is the information accurate? Barbara Wallraff, a longtime editor and columnist for the *Atlantic*, suggests that when you reread, you should ask yourself, "How do I feel about what this says? How do I feel about the writer?"

In addition to the content of your draft, review your writing style. This is the time to polish what you've written. Aim for unfussy language that's easy to read:

- **Keep your sentences short.** Your point will get lost in too many complex clauses, so break them into separate statements. And avoid loading up the text with unnecessary words.
- **Watch for language that's overly formal.** Readers will lose the thread of your argument, or simply lose their will to understand it, if your writing is stilted.

TIPS

How to write an email

When writing an email message, keep it professional and brief.

- **Pick a standard font in black.** Anything else is hard to read and raises questions about your professionalism.
- **Capitalize and punctuate properly.** No lowercase "i's" or missing question marks. Says business writing expert Bryan A. Garner, "It takes less time to write a clear message the first time around than it does to follow up to explain what you meant to say."
- **Include a short, descriptive subject line.** It will help your email stand out in a cluttered inbox, especially if it's a call to action ("Prepare for Friday's meeting").

- **Use the simpler word.** “Transmogrify” is not a better way of saying “change.” Contrary to popular belief, complex word choices don’t make you appear smarter.
- **Avoid repetition.** “I’m *excited* about this *exciting* opportunity” looks sloppy. The best way to catch these issues is to set aside your writing for a few moments and come back to it.
- **Create strong patterns.** If you present A, B, and C ideas at the beginning of the document, don’t refer to them as C, A, and B later on. Also, make your lists parallel; if the first three bullet points are complete sentences, be sure the fourth one is too.
- **Proofread for grammar and usage errors.** *Affect* versus *effect*, subject-verb agreement—don’t get caught making these common but embarrassing mistakes. Keep a reference bookmarked on your computer (for example, Mignon Fogarty’s “A Quick Guide to Avoiding Common Writing Errors,” on HBR.org).

- **Get to the point quickly.** Put key information—what you’re asking, a deadline—up front. Don’t waste words buttering up the recipient: “May I ask a favor?” is more effective than a paragraph of praise and apologies.
- **Break up big blocks of text.** People won’t read long paragraphs, so trim the fat and press return. If you can, keep the length of your emails to a single screen of reading.
- **Reread and revise before you send.** Give yourself the opportunity to fix typos and tighten your wording. The more important or extensive your recipient list, the more time you should spend on this step.

Source: Adapted from Gretchen Gavett, “The Essential Guide to Crafting a Work Email,” HBR.org, July 24, 2015.

Emails are a particularly tricky form to master, although we write them all the time; for special tips, see the box “How to write an email.” Once you’re happy with your draft, consider sharing it with colleagues as well. As a proxy for your intended audience, they can give you feedback on what is working and what isn’t.

Persuasive presentations

Presentations are a hybrid form of communication, a combination of oral speech, text, and images. They’ve become one of the standard ways professionals share information with groups and, increasingly, with individuals as well. While this format may seem less dense than a written report, it’s more challenging to put together. Visuals compete with words for the viewer’s attention, and the emphasis on images means presenters often give short shrift to basics like structure and audience.

To create a powerful presentation, you need to distinguish the slide deck itself from your presentation as a whole. Too often we elevate the deck itself as the main event, but your voice should never play second fiddle to a screen. So what *is* the right way to combine these forms?

Step 1: Decide whether you’ll use slides

Slides can be a powerful ally in your ability to communicate with an audience. They can also undermine your presentation by giving people something besides you to focus on, so use them selectively. In smaller, informal settings, it’s better to use a whiteboard or handouts than a big glowing screen. When you do use slides, create them *after* you’ve prepared your key messages.

Step 2: Plot it out

Fundamentally, presentations are a kind of storytelling, says Nancy Duarte, who works with speakers at TED talks to improve the quality of their presentations. Duarte argues that an effective presentation, like a good story, has a beginning, a middle, and an end. Within that structure, it juxtaposes the status quo—“life as the audience knows it”—and then disturbs that sta-

tus quo by introducing provocative new ideas: “Right now customers use our service mostly to get updates about their weather. But what if we could provide them with other locally specific information on demand?” Use an opening like this to set up a conflict that the rest of the presentation will work to resolve.

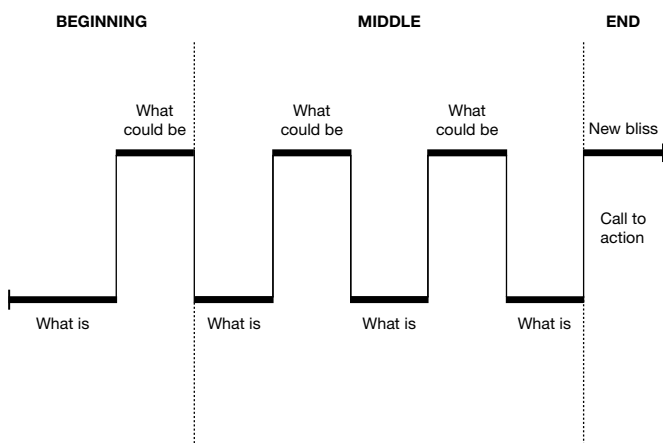
The middle of your presentation can be used to elaborate the problem and your proposed solution by going back and forth between the way things are now and the way they could be. In the scenario Duarte started, she imagines the presenter continuing:

Our backend is set up right now to provide meteorological data, but the infrastructure we’ve created could incorporate other data-sets that are similarly organized, like traffic. However, our engineering team does not have experience building out this kind of capacity. But we’re prepared to bring on experts who have worked on projects like this in the past.

Toggling between your current reality and a better, alternative future creates excitement and tension. (See exhibit 6-2.)

EXHIBIT 6-2

Persuasive story pattern



Source: Nancy Duarte, *HBR Guide to Persuasive Presentations*. Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2012.

Make a hard sell at the end of your presentation. Don't finish with a long to-do list: "next steps" followed by a dozen bullet points is not exactly inspiring. Either summarize key points for a compelling appeal to the minds of your audience or, instead, speak directly to their hearts:

After the problems with our last major expansion effort, I know we're all afraid of failing again. But if the past few years have taught us anything, it's resilience. We've worked so hard to get back in the game; finally, I think we have a project that takes advantage of everything we've learned.

Step 3: Prepare your visuals

Once you've outlined the overall narrative, it's time to make your slide deck. Think "less is more." People should be able to understand a slide in three seconds, which means you need to streamline the content aggressively. Here are Duarte's proven rules for a great deck:

- **Slideshow ≠ talk.** Don't subject your audience to a read-along; nothing is more likely to lose their attention. Don't lay out your entire argument on a slide. If you choose to use presentation notes or a teleprompter, conceal them from the audience's view.
- **One idea per slide.** People can only process a single stream of information at once. Choose text or visuals that reinforce key points (for example, an icon that illustrates a key metaphor) or that will help the audience remember your takeaways (for example, a buzzword).
- **Storyboard on sticky notes.** Their small size will force you to simplify your content, and it's easy to play around with the order. Create a full outline this way before you open up PowerPoint and start fiddling around with slide formats.
- **Fresh visuals.** Brainstorm visual concepts, a *lot* of them. It's better to pick a slightly weird metaphor or image than something tired and forgettable. For tips on displaying data, see the box "How to make data pop."

- **KISS (Keep it simple, stupid).** Pick readable, simple fonts in a large size. An occasional pop of bright color can add visual interest and conceptual emphasis, but don't let the aesthetics get in the way of legibility.

Step 4: Perform like a pro

After you've planned a well-structured presentation, get ready for the actual event:

- **Rehearse.** Don't memorize your talk word for word; it will sound stiff and boring. But know the material well enough that the environment, technology, and audience won't throw you off your game.
- **Have a plan for interacting with your audience.** When will you take comments? How will you respond if someone interrupts you or questions you aggressively? If someone asks you something you don't have an answer for?

TIPS

How to make data pop

How can you communicate the *meaning* of your data quickly?

- **Include the minimum you need to make your point.** You don't need to overwhelm the viewer with numbers; too much information is distracting and even off-putting.
- **Show the eye where to go.** Help people see what's most important by highlighting key information with bright colors and big labels.
- **Leave plenty of white space.** It will make your data look cleaner and give viewers' eyes a neutral place to rest while they're sorting out the structure of your chart.

- **Stick to the schedule.** One of the biggest ways you can show respect for your audience is by starting and ending on time. If you've allotted time for questions or other kinds of participation, honor that commitment.

Presentations are a performance with a live audience. You'll have to think on your feet and adapt the material you prepared to your listeners.

Conducting effective meetings

Whereas presentations and the written word are mostly unidirectional—I talk, you listen—meetings are participatory. You're managing not only your own communications, but everyone else's, too. By taking a little time to prepare and follow up, you'll keep the room engaged, stave off any brewing conflicts, ensure that all voices are heard, and keep the session on track and effective.

Step 1: Prepare before the meeting

Step back and ask yourself what you want the meeting you're planning to accomplish. Do you need stakeholders to make a decision? Are you sharing information with a group? Will your team brainstorm new ideas? Once you have a clear objective in mind, create an agenda. Consider what activities need to happen during the meeting to accomplish your purpose, and how these events should logically flow. Then assign a leader and a length of time for each item.

You may also decide to ask someone else to officially facilitate the meeting. This person will guide the conversation and take care of pre- and post-logistics, like sharing agendas, call-in numbers, or notes. Additional meeting roles may include a scribe, who records key ideas, disagreements, and decisions; a timekeeper, who makes sure the meeting sticks to its agenda; and experts you can call on for an opinion.

When you plan your attendee list, include key decision makers, experts, and stakeholders. Run your list by key attendees to make sure you're not missing anyone important or including anyone extraneous. The number of

attendees should depend on the meeting's purpose: a general rule of thumb is to invite fewer people if you're meeting to make a decision and more if you're brainstorming or sharing updates.

Finally, you (or your facilitator) will need to prepare the logistics. Make sure the room is set up, including projector hookups and teleconferencing technology. Distribute materials ahead of time, including the agenda and any necessary background readings.

As a busy manager, you'll be tempted to skip some of this preparation for your standing or routine meetings. If you want people to be excited about your meetings, do the work up front to make them productive and meaningful.

Step 2: Conduct the meeting

Start on time and begin by explaining the group's goals and introducing each person's role—for example, the facilitator or timekeeper. Then establish some ground rules for how you'll conduct the conversation—whether you expect people to put away their phones and laptops, how those participating virtually should jump into the conversation, who is the decision maker, and so forth.

As the meeting progresses, keep everyone engaged by highlighting agenda transitions, summarizing progress, and underscoring major decisions or announcements. Empower the timekeeper to signal when you're going over or to interrupt a speaker, if necessary, to keep moving forward.

Efficiency in a meeting should never come at the cost of full participation, however. Ask the whole group, "Have we forgotten anything?" "Does anyone have a different point of view?" Be prepared to shut down people who talk too much and draw out the silent types. Keep an eye out for body language that indicates someone wants to contribute—leaning forward, quick indrawn breaths, eye contact. If someone hasn't spoken at all during the meeting, elicit his thoughts. And give virtual participants verbal cues (for more tips on this, see the box "Tips: How to run a virtual meeting").

When you're ready to close, repeat the key points of the conversation, including decisions, next steps, and personnel assignments, and check for

TIPS

How to run a virtual meeting

Virtual meetings present special challenges. Will the virtual participants be able to follow what's going on? How will you keep people's attention when you're not in the same room? Keith Ferrazzi, a leadership consultant and researcher, lays out these best practices for creating a strong sense of group identity without slowing down the meeting:

- **Use video if possible.** When we can see each other's faces, we feel more connected with one another and more engaged with the topic of the meeting. By watching facial expressions, you'll also be able to perceive vital information about your team's emotional responses and buy-in. At a minimum, consider using photos in materials distributed so everyone has a visual reference for those remote to the location.
- **Have the team provide updates in advance.** Instead of having everyone provide a status update during the meeting (like "a bunch of fifth-graders reading to each other around the table," says Ferrazzi), ask participants to send out a half-page report ahead of time on key agenda items. Make it clear that everyone is expected to prepare for the meeting by reviewing these messages, as well as the rest of the agenda. People should come prepared to have a truly informed discussion.
- **Kill the mute button.** In theory, using the mute button is good etiquette because it prevents disruptions for the rest of the group. In fact, it's a license to multitask, even to leave the room mid-meeting. It's rude, and it can put a serious dent in the meeting's liveliness and productivity. You can also limit multitasking by calling on participants directly to contribute or by rotating the roles of timekeeper or scribe.

Source: Keith Ferrazzi, "How to Run a Great Virtual Meeting," HBR.org, March 27, 2015.

understanding. Then end with motivational message: “Great discussion today, thanks so much. We got a lot done!”

Step 3: Follow up afterward

Send a follow-up note the next day, summarizing what the team accomplished and holding members accountable for future progress. Stick to high-level details:

- Decisions or outcomes you want people to remember
- Who is responsible for next steps, including you
- Due dates attached to those action items

Send the note to all attendees and anyone else who needs to know what happened.

If any members seemed dissatisfied during the discussion, follow up with them individually, preferably in person so you can discuss their concerns face-to-face. You might learn something important that never came up in the meeting itself, or you might hear useful feedback about your own leadership, and you’ll gain buy-in for the group’s work down the road.

From memos to meetings, effective communication that engages your audience’s attention will help to persuade someone to your way of thinking. In the long term, though, the benefits are much greater. The more effectively you communicate, the more influential you become.

Recap

- Finding your voice as a leader involves learning a set of rhetorical tactics and behaviors and incorporating them into your authentic way of speaking.
- All types of written communications benefit from taking a moment to prepare and review, so you’re presenting your thoughts in the most compelling and professional light.

100 Managing Yourself

- When creating a presentation, consider the slide deck and the meat of your presentation separately.
- For a meeting to be effective, you need to prepare the agenda and invitation list carefully, and elicit all participants' viewpoints during the meeting itself.

Action items

To find your voice as a leader:

- ☐ Pick one rhetorical tool and try it out in a conversation. Contrasts, three-part lists, and expressions of moral conviction or shared sentiment will seem more natural in day-to-day interactions, whereas metaphors, similes, and analogies should be reserved for larger, more formal discussions.
- ☐ Choose emotionally heightened conversations to try new tactics. Practice your new skills when you're debriefing a direct report in your office, for example, not just making small talk in the parking lot. Serious interactions will give you better fodder, and you'll have more time to pause and gather your thoughts before you speak.
- ☐ Observe yourself speak. Make a video of yourself as part of your practice; it's much more realistic than just watching yourself in a mirror. Choose something informal like a status update or a more elaborate script you wrote for a past presentation. Review the video to observe your facial expressions and gestures: How animated are you? Work on one specific behavior—for example, smiling—and practice it in all your interactions for the rest of the day.

When you need to write something:

- ☐ Prepare by knowing what you *really* want to say (write three sentences), understanding who your audience is, and deciding on an organizing method.
- ☐ Write your first draft quickly. Don't necessarily start at the beginning.

- ☐ When you edit, review the content, polish your style, and check your grammar and usage. Aim for simplicity instead of trying to sound impressive.

When planning a presentation:

- ☐ Plot your presentation out in narrative form before you even open your computer. Tell a story with a beginning, middle, and end.
- ☐ Decide whether you'll be using slides.
- ☐ Prepare your visuals. Storyboard your presentation with sticky notes, and limit yourself to one idea per slide.
- ☐ Perform like a pro by practicing ahead of time. During the presentation itself, stick to your schedule.

When running a meeting:

- ☐ Prepare for the meeting by defining your purpose, creating an agenda, inviting attendees, assigning roles, and prepping logistics.
- ☐ During the meeting, establish your ground rules for group interactions, keep things moving, and make sure all voices are heard. Close the meeting on time by summarizing your accomplishments and next steps.
- ☐ Follow up afterward by sending a note to all attendees. Seek out critics to discuss (and disarm) their opposition.



7.

Personal Productivity

You did a great job juggling all your many tasks as an individual contributor; that's probably one of the things your organization saw when it chose to promote you. But many new managers are surprised by how much more they're responsible for now: not just more work, but more *kinds* of work, all seemingly top priority. You need to think strategically and plan for the future, while optimizing execution every day. You can feel as if these responsibilities are pulling you in a hundred different directions at once: "Did you see my email?" "I need you to take this over." "Could you help with this?" "What's your plan for the next fiscal year?" "When are you going to be home for dinner?"

To orchestrate your time and your energy so you can meet all these demands, you must manage your *personal productivity*. That phrase covers everything from corraling your calendar to understanding tricks to make you more productive and help you relax. In this chapter, you'll learn how to prioritize calls for your attention, stay focused, and keep stress—and work—from controlling your life.

Time management essentials

Your time is valuable. Time management is a deliberate practice that helps ensure you're using all the time available to you in the best way possible. You may not feel able to justify the effort it takes. But the payoff is worth it. It will allow you to see patterns and begin making adjustments so you can get the *right* work done at the right time and become more effective.

Step 1: Understand how you spend your time now

A schedule is like a budget, says Elizabeth Grace Saunders, a time management coach: you can't manage your assets unless you understand your current spending habits. Start by logging your activities for at least a day or two, preferably for an entire week. Use a time-tracking or calendar app or a simple spreadsheet, noting your activities in half-hour increments, as well as any major interruptions. Keep track of unplanned activities like fielding phone calls in the middle of a meeting or dipping into administrative work when you're supposedly preparing a presentation.

Step 2: Look for patterns

When you've completed your log, collect the activities into five to ten categories and tally the minutes you've spent on each. Consider categories like answering emails, planning, dealing with crises, project work, managing people, administrative work, relaxing time, personal chores done at work, and professional development.

Now analyze the data you've collected. How are you distributing your time across all these activities? How much time do you spend on planning, compared with crises and fires? How much time do you spend on your own project work, versus managing your team members? As you look at your tallies, what surprises you?

Now step back and ask yourself the most important question of all: *Does my time usage match my highest priorities?* What's the payoff associated with each activity? Which activities are tied to your core responsibilities and which aren't so relevant? Which investments have the highest

impact for you, personally and professionally? For example, assess whether you are spending more time on a side project than you should, not enough time planning for the future, and whether you are taking enough breaks in your day to stay productive. Are there activities you've been doing that really should be performed by someone else—or not at all? Look for items that you might hand off to a colleague or a direct report.

Step 3: Make a goal-driven master plan

Look at your list of activity categories and allocate time to each based on your goals and priorities. You'll have to make smart trade-offs here, and it might take some iteration to get right. The first time through, ask yourself: "In an ideal world, how much time would I spend on these activities?" These numbers may not add up to forty or even sixty hours each week. So the second time, ask yourself, "What's the minimum amount of time I can afford to spend on these activities?" Minimize the amount of time you are spending on low-priority items; this can free up time for more important work.

In a well-balanced schedule, however, your highest-priority items may end up occupying only a small fraction of your time, and that's OK. Your mission here is only to find *enough* time in your schedule to meet these goals, and if that's a mere five or ten hours a week, that's fine.

Step 4: Execute your plan: time boxing

Now it's time to allocate the time you've assigned to each item into a schedule. Using a technique called *time boxing*, you'll break your schedule into short blocks and then slot a category into each block, breaking it up into tasks. (See exhibit 7-1.)

Start by reviewing the week ahead: What deadlines, meetings, and tasks are coming up? What longer-term commitments do you need to work on in this time frame? Then prioritize that task list. Put deadline-sensitive items up top ("Prepare for presentation on Wednesday"), followed by goal-oriented actions ("Research strategic plan"). You'll schedule both of these around your recurring obligations ("Weekly staff meeting"). Note the categories that these tasks fall into.

EXHIBIT 7-1

Time-boxing tool

Schedule for Monday and Tuesday mornings

Time	Monday	Tuesday
8:00 a.m.	Planning Task: Prepare for budget presentation on Wednesday Actual time spent:	Planning Task: Research SP Actual time spent:
9:00 a.m.	Planning Task: Research strategic plan (SP) Actual time spent:	Project work Task: Follow up on new leads Actual time spent:
10:00 a.m.	Managing others Task: Plan to delegate invoicing to Ivan Task: Review résumés for administrative as- sistant position Actual time spent:	Managing others Task: Meet with Ivan about invoicing Actual time spent:
		Personal tasks Task: Call Mom for her birthday Actual time spent:
11:00 a.m.	Communication Task: Respond to emails Task: Call Asana back Actual time spent:	Team meetings Task: Weekly staff meeting Actual time spent:

Source: Harvard Business Review, *Managing Time* (20-Minute Manager Series). Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2014.

Next, allocate a specific block of time to each category. Within each box, list the tasks you’ll accomplish. As you go, calculate the amount of time you are spending on each category so you match your allocations in step 3.

Put the time boxes into your actual calendar, wherever you keep track of your appointments, so you treat your boxes with the same respect as you would a meeting with your boss.

As you begin, it’s much better to overestimate how much time each task will take than to underestimate. But for this technique to work, you need to be able to make accurate time estimates, so keep track of how your

schedules work out. You can use these experiences to make a better plan next time.

Finding focus

Even with a perfectly calibrated schedule, disciplining your attention can be difficult. You have a big task to work on, and you know when you have to work on it, but you just got five emails while doing your *last* task. Or you have a problem from yesterday that you still haven't solved, or a deadline for another project looming tomorrow. A news story you're antsy to check up on. A sheaf of papers that's not aligned *quite so* with the corner of your desk.

Finding your focus is about learning how to tune out all this mental noise so you can concentrate on the work at hand. That concentration can be powerful. Psychologists call it “flow”—when you're so completely engaged in what you're doing that you lose track of time. Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, who pioneered research on flow, describes the concept this way:

Imagine that you are skiing down a slope and your full attention is focused on the movements of your body, the position of the skis, the air whistling past your face, and the snow-shrouded trees running by. There is no room in your awareness for conflicts or contradictions; you know that a distracting thought or emotion might get you buried face down in the snow. The run is so perfect that you want it to last forever.

Flow boosts both performance and motivation. You do your best work in this state, and you feel good about yourself, too. But to achieve it, you need to eliminate the behaviors and environmental cues that send your brain off-task.

Forestall interruptions

Interruptions often take you away from the task at hand for much longer than you had planned. Diving back in is hard: according to research at

the University of California–Irvine, getting back on track after being interrupted can take more than twenty minutes.

Plan ahead for these obstacles and temptations. When you need to focus, close your door or put up a “do not disturb” sign. Turn off notifications on your phone and computer, at least for email and chat applications. Consider disabling your Wi-Fi entirely, or use a service to block certain websites for a given amount of time. Experiment with different tactics, and don’t be afraid to tell your colleagues about your efforts: “I’m going to be working on the budget presentation early this afternoon, so I’ll be off email

TIPS

How to protect your time from other people

Your direct reports come to you for help or a decision; your peers want your support for their own goals; and from time to time, your boss wants a favor, too. Being smart about how you respond to these requests will let you make the most of your time and still support your colleagues appropriately.

- **Know when to say no.** When someone asks for a favor or offers an opportunity, ask yourself: Is this work valuable to my organization? Is it important to my professional goals? Is it important to me personally? Am I the *only* person who could do this task? If I say no, will I damage the relationship? If none of these questions elicit a strong yes, then that’s a good sign you shouldn’t do it.
- **Learn how to say no.** If you’ve decided that it isn’t something you can do, politely decline, delegate, or suggest a replacement. Some scripts for these awkward conversations:
 - “Thanks for thinking of me. Unfortunately my plate is full at the moment, and I have to say no. I’ll look forward to seeing how your project turns out.”

until after three.” If you *are* interrupted, know how to refuse a request or end a conversation if you need to get back to work (see the box “Tips: How to protect your time from other people”).

Organize your space

If your environment is disordered, you’ll spend precious minutes looking for materials you need to get work done. You’ll also be more vulnerable to distraction, as other objects or obligations catch your eye. Here’s what you can do to make your office conducive to focus:

- “I can’t take this on right now, but I’d like to offer the opportunity to Omar. He’s been looking for a chance to take on more leadership in our team, and I think he’d handle this really well.”
- For your boss: “I’m not certain I can take this on successfully with my current set of priorities. I could use your guidance on what’s most important to you.”
- **Exit conversations.** Sometimes all people want from you is your attention and even that’s too much. But escaping from an enthusiastic conversationalist can be uncomfortable, so try these scripts:
 - “Do you want to continue this conversation over lunch tomorrow? Right now I have to get back to work.”
 - “Can you send me an email about your question, so I can follow up later? Right now I need to finish this task.”
 - “Sorry, someone’s waiting for this work so I need to get it done now. Can I swing by your desk in an hour?”
 - “I hate to cut you off, but . . .” “Sorry to be rude, but . . .”

Eliminate the clutter.

If your workspace is really a mess, set aside a block of time to clean it up. What papers can you file? Pass on to someone else? Throw away? Once you've completed the initial purge, get in the habit of tidying up your desk when you're transitioning between tasks.

Keep what you need within reach.

Put objects you use every day on your desk—a particular notebook, a pad of sticky notes, your headphones. Store everything else in a drawer, out of sight. This might feel odd at first, but it helps significantly with focus.

Make yourself comfortable.

Do you get a crick in your neck when you look at your computer monitor for too long? Does your desk chair give you a backache? Adjust the height and positioning of these objects, and make sure the rest of your space is aesthetically pleasing to you, too. Harsh light or busy sightlines can be as distracting as a loud noise when your brain is restless.

Organize your email

An update from your employee. A question from a client. An invitation from your boss. You'll have to respond to these messages at some point, but when you expose yourself to a stream of notifications, you undermine your ability to meet the priorities you've already established for yourself. Email can become an excuse to procrastinate when you fall out of flow on a project, and it doesn't serve you well to allow email to hinder you from completing important work. Here's what you can do to keep the mayhem in check:

Clean up your inbox.

The guilt or stress you feel over unanswered messages can be as intrusive as a new notification, so just as you set time aside to clean your physical space, also make time to clean your virtual space. Sort your emails by sender and delete the backlog of messages you don't need, as well as the ones you've already responded to. Then create three folders in which to file all the emails

that are still in your inbox: follow-up, hold, and archive. Messages that require a thoughtful response go into the *follow-up* folder, while notes about future events, like an invitation, go into *hold*. *Archive* everything that requires no further action, but that you still want to keep a record of. Going forward, use this system to sort new emails as they arrive.

Start over.

If you don't have time to go through all your old messages, don't. Put them all in a separate archive folder and start fresh with a new inbox. This strategy might seem ruthless—you totally *were* going to get to all those messages someday!—but if you honestly can't sort through fourteen thousand unread messages, declaring “email bankruptcy” allows you to move on and focus on your future productivity. But save this move for emergencies only; don't develop a reputation as someone who is nonresponsive by leveraging this option too often.

Turn off notifications.

If you really need to concentrate, turn off notifications or close your email client altogether. Set up an auto-reply for the time you're offline: “I'm stepping away from email until five to get some work done, but you can reach me by phone or text if something urgent comes up.”

Stress management

Stress and lack of focus are actually two parts of a vicious cycle. You can't focus, so you don't get work done. When you don't get work done, you become too stressed to focus. And repeat.

“Stress is a physiological response to any change, whether good or bad, that alerts the adaptive fight-or-flight response of the brain and body,” says Dr. Herbert Benson, founder of the Mind/Body Medical Institute and an associate professor of medicine at Harvard Medical School. Maybe a colleague caught you off guard with a difficult question during a presentation, or perhaps your boss just added another urgent assignment to your already full plate. Sometimes internal issues trigger stress, like when you

worry about failing at a new and difficult assignment. The likelihood of managers experiencing stress in the workplace is very high in today's fast-paced and complex organizations.

There is *some* good stress, of course. Stress is a natural, even useful reaction that can motivate you and help you focus under pressure. Business culture often seizes on this; how often have you been asked, as motivation in the face of a big challenge, if you are tough enough, smart enough, committed enough to succeed.

The best managers know how to balance the benefit of stress, while protecting from the negative impact of stress. According to psychiatrist and attention deficit disorder expert Edward Hallowell, too much stress actively sabotages your ability to perform: "When you are confronted with the sixth decision after the fifth interruption in the midst of a search for the ninth missing piece of information on the day that the third deal has collapsed and the twelfth impossible request has blipped unbidden across your computer screen, your brain begins to panic, reacting just as if that sixth decision were a blood-thirsty, man-eating tiger." The result: bad stress. The signs can include uncontrollable anxiety, disorganization, and even anger, disengagement, physical exhaustion, and illness, all of which lead to poor performance, not to mention a lower quality of life.

These reactions are a matter of neurochemistry, not moral fitness. The frontal lobes of your brain, where nuanced cognition like decision making, planning, and learning happen, start sending distress signals to the deep regions of the brain that govern your survival instincts. And those regions respond with a range of powerful, primitive signals: fear, alarm, withdrawal.

All this means that your ability to evaluate information and solve problems crashes just as the rest of your mind and body lock into crisis mode. "In survival mode," says Hallowell, "the manager makes impulsive judgments, angrily rushing to bring closure to whatever matter is at hand."

To better manage your reactions, establish routines that will regulate your general stress levels and adopt practices to relieve high tensions in the moment. The more effectively you monitor yourself, the more you'll be able to help your team members manage their stress, too.

Routines to regulate stress

Your daily life contains many sources of stress, even before you factor in a big deadline or sick child. By adopting healthy habits like these, you can protect your personal reserves from that everyday wear and tear:

Promote positive emotions.

Foster a trusting, respectful culture among your team members where you can derive comfort from your colleagues even in crisis. Spend time on emotionally rewarding relationships at work, even if they're not strategic, and express appreciation regularly. Make a habit of toggling between the task you're working on now and the big picture, so you can take pleasure in the progress you've made and touch base with what's really motivating you. When you start to feel overwhelmed, breathe deeply and cut yourself some slack. Develop a ritual for regularly thinking about meaning, perhaps each day as you get ready to leave. The more consciously you connect your work to a larger sense of purpose—whether that's changing the world or securing your own financial stability—the better you'll be able to weather each day's ups and downs.

Take care of your brain and body.

Being attentive to your physical well-being will lower your stress at work and improve your ability to lead. The value of sleep cannot be overstated. Stay rested by setting an early bedtime. Diet is important, too. Eat healthy foods at intervals that make you feel your best. Limit alcohol intake. Finally, exercise releases a host of stress-fighting chemicals, and you don't need to be a marathon runner to reap the benefits. Walking up and down a flight of stairs or down a hallway a few times a day will do the trick.

Reduce the stress of everyday decision making.

You have a limited amount of mental energy, so don't spend it on low-impact decisions like, "What should I have for breakfast this morning?" or "When should I go through my voice mails?" Put these choices on autopilot by limiting your options (granola or a Danish) or establishing a routine

(checking your voice mail at ten each morning). Social psychologist Heidi Halvorson suggests you give yourself extra support around difficult decisions by constructing “if-then” propositions in advance: “*If* I find out our budget isn’t being increased, *then* I will go for a walk around the block to stay calm and relaxed.”

In-the-moment interventions

Establishing patterns, good habits, and routines should help you stay calm as you go about your normal daily life. But when something specific causes your stress levels to rise, take a short break to disrupt that tiger-fighting survival response:

Do something else.

People do better with difficult tasks when they’re fresh off something simpler, like an easy rote task. You could talk with a friend, solve a fun puzzle, or even write a short description of something you know well, like your house. You’re giving your brain some breathing room to reset its circuits.

Step away.

If you have an emotional response while interacting with others, excuse yourself from the meeting you’re in or graciously end the phone call. It’s better to take a moment to govern your reaction than have an uncontrolled emotional response. Don’t be embarrassed to let others know what you’re doing: “I need a moment to process all this, so I can bring a clear mind back to the table. Let’s take a ten-minute break.”

Try desk yoga.

If you need some physical relief from the tension but you can’t leave your desk, try a few office-friendly stretches. You can slowly roll your shoulders, alternating left and right, or use your hand to gently press your ear to your shoulder. Flex your clasped hands behind you to stretch your chest, or twist your torso at the waist, keeping your feet flat on the floor. Breathe deeply and let your muscles relax into each pose for ten to fifteen breaths.

Work-life balance

For many professionals, the daily tug of war between work and time with family, friends, community, and self is in itself a source of stress. Where does work end for you? When you close your computer for the day? When you physically leave the office? When you enter your home? Greet your family? Fall asleep? Does it *ever* end?

Work-life balance is how you organize the relationship between your professional and personal lives. It includes the habits you rely on to protect and renew your energy, the boundaries you set around family and leisure time, and the strategies you use to negotiate conflicts between the two.

Here are the best practices for finding synergy where you can and drawing lines where you can't:

Avoid burnout

In addition to your other routines to regulate stress, take breaks during the workday to refresh your energy, like checking in with someone you love or going for a walk around the block. Avoid surfing the internet as a break strategy, as it tends to deplete your motivation; focus instead of replenishing it. Even staring out your window is better.

In the evenings, build in time when you can truly recharge. Instead of sitting on your sofa watching television, do something that actively engages your brain in a pleasurable way, like cooking a meal or visiting with a friend. After a certain time each night, put your digital devices away in a drawer or a closet and maintain a strict “no email” rule. In addition to whatever family time you set aside, be sure you also get some “me” time.

Protect your weekend

Weekends are your time for regular rest, recovery, and human connection. Even if you can't promise yourself a clear forty-eight hours, do set some boundaries around when you'll read and answer emails or work on important projects.

The best way to uphold these boundaries, of course, is to be strategic with your time during the week. Negotiate deadlines that you can't reasonably meet in a five-day workweek, and frontload your schedule so you're not tackling all the important tasks at the end of the week. Finally, give yourself a compelling reason *not* to work by committing to personal plans for the weekend. If other people are counting on you to show up at a concert or go to a soccer game, you'll be more motivated to tie up loose ends before you leave on Friday.

Own your relationships

Sometimes work *will* take over everything else. Whether your business lost an important client or you're going through a seasonal busy period, you can manage the impact on your most important relationships and negotiate reasonable expectations in advance. The people closest to you—like your spouse and family—may struggle with your work-life balance as much as you do. Your best bet: talk about it.

Start the conversation by providing context about why your work is so intense right now and explain the purpose of all this effort: "By putting in all this time now, I'm helping my team prepare the best presentation we can make to potential investors. When we can bring another investor onboard, the company's finances will stabilize and my job will stop being so crisis driven."

Then ask about what this shift in your work means for them: "Can you tell me how you think this will make things harder for you?" If you disagree, ask for more information: "Can you give an example to help me understand?" Don't minimize or debate their point of view. Exercise compassion and express genuine remorse for the hurt they're feeling. And be specific; if you can't give loved ones your full attention and presence during this time, you can at least show them you understand and care about what they're feeling.

Talk to them, too, about how you might minimize the impact: "How can I make this better for us, our family, our relationship?" Also ask how you could handle things better in the future. Bring up difficult situations

you think might develop: “School is ending soon, which means new schedules for our kids and more child care overall. What are your thoughts about what I can do when that changes?”

This conversation has two purposes for you. First, you want to reaffirm your connection with the person you care about and to be transparent about what makes this situation so hard. But you’re also looking for fixes that would mitigate the negative effects your work is having on the relationship. Stewart Friedman, a professor at the Wharton School, suggests that you might be holding yourself to higher, or at least different, standards than your loved ones do. Maybe your daughter doesn’t care if you miss dinner, as long as you can still drive her to school in the morning. Or maybe your parent doesn’t mind if you miss some family dinners, as long as you continue to participate in a shared community activity. You won’t know unless you ask.

Recognize that it’s not a zero-sum game

Friedman argues that work-life “balance” itself is a misnomer. Work, family and friends, community, and self-development will always be in flux, and there will never be a perfect equilibrium between them. And work is a *part* of life, after all. You vent and celebrate your achievements with your family, trade war stories and seek professional advice with your friends, share your expertise and build your skills in your community. And the leadership growth you bring to each of these spheres will help you in the others, like the executive Friedman coached who gained leadership experience and strengthened his relationship with his family by joining a local community board in his neighborhood.

To develop your career sustainably, you need to integrate these parts of your life without sacrificing your own happiness. Friedman argues that your professional future actually hinges on your ability to preserve a rich life outside work. Authentic leaders ground themselves in a clear understanding of who they are and what they value, which is borne out in human experiences outside the office as well as in it.

There’s something even more elemental at stake here than your job: your health and happiness. A bad work-life balance can undermine your

health in a variety of ways, from hypertension and poor sleep to depression and substance abuse. The cost to your relationships will also be high. If you take a deliberate approach to balancing and combining your personal and professional duties, you can protect your health and help your family pull through times of stress *with* you.

To achieve your strategic objectives in this role and feel satisfied with your life overall, you need to take charge of your personal productivity. Learning how to manage your time, focus, and stress frees you up to think about the bigger picture and get the most out of each day. Do this for yourself, your colleagues, your team members, and your loved ones, who all need you operating at your best.

Recap

- Managing your time is a deliberate practice that will help ensure you are using all the time available in the best way possible, matching up the time you have available with your goals and priorities.
- As important as finding time to do your work is finding focus in order to do it well.
- Stress is a physiological response to change, and it comes in good and bad flavors. Embrace positive stress and develop patterns to mitigate unhealthy stress.
- To minimize your stress, invest time to care for your body and your brain.
- Work-life “balance” may be a misnomer; aim for positive work-life integration.

Action items

To get a handle on your time:

- ☐ Understand how you use your time by tracking at a very detailed level for a few days.
- ☐ Look for patterns in the data you've collected about your time use: Does it match your priorities? Analyze what's creating the gaps between your expectations and reality.
- ☐ Make a goal-driven master plan mapping how much time you'd ideally spend on each work activity, differentiating your highest and lowest priorities.
- ☐ Execute your plan by allocating time proactively to your highest priorities with time boxing on your calendar.

To improve your focus:

- ☐ Clear your primary work surface. Leave out items you use all the time, and sort the rest into storage or the trash.
- ☐ Get comfortable. Adjust the height and positioning of your computer and your chair so you can work without any pain. If you don't have a comfortable chair, acquire one today.
- ☐ Clear your inbox. Sort emails if you have time or dump them all in a backup folder for later reference. Develop a consistent habit for how you'll proactively manage email moving forward.

To better manage stress and your work-life balance:

- ☐ Commit to reconnect to the meaning of your work at the start of every week. Remind yourself why you do what you do to rediscover your inspiration.
- ☐ Limit the toll of decision making by adopting consistent routines for the things you do everyday (get dressed, check in at home, and so on).

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- ☐ When you're feeling especially stressed, give your brain and body a moment to recoup by doing a puzzle or some stretches.
- ☐ Build in time to relax during the workweek so you don't burn out. Protect your weekend by keeping Thursday and Friday free of major deadlines whenever possible.
- ☐ Look ahead to any big deadlines that might pose challenges to your personal relationships and sit down with the people involved to let them know what's coming and to brainstorm together about fixes that might alleviate some of the stress.



8.

Self-Development

For your career to be fulfilling, it's important to actively manage your own growth. Too often, people assume if they work hard, their career will unfold the way they hope. But because of the fast pace of global innovation and change, professionals must update their skills and broaden their abilities more frequently than ever before.

You are the best advocate for your own interests. Your manager juggles multiple responsibilities and priorities, and may discuss your career aspirations only at an annual performance review. Your manager will also appreciate your proactive willingness to set goals, keep your expertise current, and ask for growth opportunities. While many organizations support career growth through training and other programs, a lot of the work of self-development will depend on what *you* make happen through your own choices and actions.

For most people, the idea of a “lifetime” career is passé. Imagine, instead, your career unfolding on a lattice, not a ladder. A lattice is a broad, flexible structure that allows for multiple routes to many destinations, versus the simple “up” imperative of a ladder. This chapter will help you progress along your career lattice by discovering your interests and values, finding opportunities for growth, cultivating new skills in light of what

your organization and industry will need in the future, and forging relationships within your company and industry.

Career purpose

The first step in your self-development is articulating your career *purpose*. What do you want out of your work? How should your career fit into your life overall? What do you hope to accomplish as a leader?

Clayton Christensen, a professor at Harvard Business School, says this is the single most important thing he teaches his students each year—to “keep the purpose of their lives front and center as they [decide] how to spend their time, talents, and energy.” That’s because without a sense of

QUESTIONNAIRE

Find your purpose

Think about these questions as you plan your personal and professional development.

- **What are you good at?** How can you get better at those things? What biases do you have about what’s worth mastering?
- **What do you enjoy doing?** What activities or pastimes did you especially love when you were a child, before the world told you what you should or shouldn’t like or do?
- **How do you work best with other people?** Do you prefer to work alone or with others? What kind of relationship is most generative for you—as a subordinate, a supervisor, a peer, or a collaborator? Do you produce better results as a decision maker or an adviser?
- **Do you perform well in the presence of ambiguity?** Or do you need a highly structured and predictable environment?

purpose, you won't know how to react to the challenges and opportunities that come your way.

To develop your sense of purpose, think about important questions we often sideline in our day-to-day work lives (see the box “Questionnaire: Find your purpose”).

Nick Craig (president of the Authentic Leadership Institute) and Scott Snook (senior lecturer at Harvard Business School) have trained thousands of managers and executives. They recommend that once you have answered questions like these, you construct a simple, positive statement of purpose based on your responses. There is no one format or single right approach to developing your statement of purpose. Just tap into what resonates with you. It's OK if the statement you craft doesn't quite fit on the

- **What are your values?** What kind of person do you want to see in the mirror each morning? What organizational missions or cultures are compatible with your values?
- **Where do you belong?** What does all your self-knowledge tell you about where you can be successful and happy? What type of organization, doing what type of work, with what kind of people, to serve what positive outcome?
- **What should you contribute?** Think about your current work and your overall position in life. What needs do you see around you? Given your strengths, your way of performing, and your values, what unique and significant contributions can you make to fill these needs?
- **Think about two of your most challenging life experiences.** How have they shaped you?

Source: Adapted from Clayton M. Christensen, “How Will You Measure Your Life?,” *Harvard Business Review*, July–August 2010; Peter F. Drucker, “Managing Oneself,” *Harvard Business Review*, January 2005; and Nick Craig and Scott A. Snook, “From Purpose to Impact,” *Harvard Business Review*, May 2014.

first try. As you revise, push yourself to make it more concise and direct, and ask other people for their reactions. Does it sound like *you*? Does it capture your essence?

Your statement of purpose will serve as the foundation for the self-development strategy you'll work on in the rest of this chapter. Return to it periodically, when you're making a big decision or working through a particularly stressful period. And keep it in your back pocket as you continue to consider your own growth and development. Your purpose may shift over time, so reviewing it periodically and adapting it to your current thinking is very powerful.

Look for opportunities within your organization

Once you're clear on your career purpose, begin to look for opportunities to grow toward those goals. Maybe you want to expand certain skills with your current role by taking on special projects or stretch assignments. Or you may feel that you've accomplished what you wanted to in your current role, and you're ready for the next step in your career—a permanent role or a tour of duty in which you learn about a different part of the organization.

Consider starting your search for more within your current company. First, you've invested time and effort building your reputation, earning trust, and establishing credibility there. You're also familiar with the culture. Your strongest networks also operate within your organization, which means you may have more access to opportunities in-house than in the broader industry. Your company has also likely invested a great deal to develop your talents; you have knowledge and experience it doesn't want to lose. In some cases, you'll want to consider other organizations (if your current situation is highly toxic or you want to learn how a different kind of business operates), but it usually makes sense to start close to home.

Step 1: Investigate formal development

Begin with your company's formal process for developing talent. Your supervisor is responsible for helping direct reports clarify their goals and find appropriate growth opportunities, so make an appointment with them

first. Come prepared to talk about the direction in which you'd like to grow. Ask questions about the opportunities available to you. If you feel comfortable, share your statement of purpose and ask for your boss's reactions and ideas.

Other sources of information at this stage could include:

- Your company's human resources department
- Formal training programs, such as leadership training provided by your organization, technical apprenticeships, or outside degree programs that your company will underwrite
- Company job postings for current openings
- Internal networks that may support your development, either your own web of influence or connections organized through HR
- Mentoring relationships, either formally organized by HR or undertaken through your own initiative
- Temporary assignments—for example, taking on new tasks during a colleague's maternity leave or sabbatical

Step 2: Conduct internal informational interviews

Informational interviews are a good way to gather more insight about any of these options. For example, if you're wondering if you'd want to transfer to another department, you might ask HR to set up a conversation with an employee or manager there. Or, if your boss knows about and supports your ambitions, you could ask them to introduce you to someone there. Use a referral when possible; hiring managers are especially open to meeting with someone who's been recommended by an acquaintance they respect. (See also the box "Case study: When interviews yield offers.")

When you sit down with your colleague, remember that you're there to learn, not to ask for a job (at least not yet). You should be prepared to lead the conversation. Come armed with research and good questions. A good place to start is with these five questions based on work by career strategist Daniel Porot:

- “How did you get into this line of work?”
- “What do you enjoy about it?”
- “What’s not so great about it?”
- “What’s changing in the sector?”
- “What kinds of people do well in this industry?”

CASE STUDY

When interviews yield offers

Informational interviews within your company can help you form connections, but conversations with those outside your organization can also help give you perspective. In either case, you need to prepare before taking the time of those who are helping you.

Two years ago, Matt McConnell, who lives in Southern California, wanted to move from finance to marketing. He wasn’t entirely sure of his direction, so he began using informational interviews to learn about other people’s careers in the hopes of narrowing his focus. “I was also using the interviews to learn more about other organizations to see whether they might be places I’d want to work,” he says.

His first informational interview didn’t go very well, and Matt takes full responsibility. “I didn’t prepare,” he recalls. “He could tell, and he told me that I was wasting his time.”

Matt learned an important lesson. “I’ve never made that mistake again. I now always overprepare,” he says.

To get ready, he reads people’s LinkedIn profiles, does a Google search on their careers, and checks out their company’s website. He tends to ask the same questions, usually in the realm of how the person got started and how they ended up in their current role. “But I also make

Respect your interviewee's time: ask for no more than twenty minutes, and honor the time limit. Thank them afterward with a handwritten note.

Step 3: Propose a job

Sometimes interviewing for an open job posting or having an informational interview leads to a new role that's just what you want. But if it doesn't, don't give up. Instead, propose the job you *want* to do. This takes

notes about particular questions I want to ask so that I have something to reference if the conversation stalls," he says.

Matt also has a postmeeting routine. "I ask for a business card and immediately send a handwritten thank-you note. The thank-you is typically three lines long, and I always mention one specific thing from our meeting that resonated with me so they know I was listening and found their time valuable," he says.

"Early on in my career I worried that I didn't have anything to offer anyone in return. [But] I learned that people enjoyed sharing their experiences and offering advice, so I make sure to communicate my sincere gratitude."

Matt eventually had an informational interview with a marketing head of a quick-service restaurant group that yielded results. "After our meeting, the person called me and said her company was hiring for a role she thought I'd be perfect for," he says. "She'd given my name to the HR department, and they were planning on calling me within the next thirty minutes to do a phone interview. That phone interview led to in-person interviews and eventually a job offer at that company."

He worked at the company for a few years before moving on. He's now the marketing manager for Astrophysics, a company that designs X-ray scanners for security screenings.

Source: Rebecca Knight, "How to Get the Most Out of an Informational Interview," HBR.org, February 26, 2016.

a lot of preparation, but can be highly effective in leveraging your skills to the benefit of your organization. You can start by researching unseen opportunities within your organization. What customer or internal need is unaddressed? Where could the organization grow? Try to imagine your company as an outsider would see it and gather as much information as you can from colleagues, company meetings, shareholder conference calls, and other venues. Here are some questions that can guide your search:

- **Which departments or business areas have momentum?** A department that's growing rapidly may be eager to add someone who is already familiar with the organization's mission and culture.
- **What opportunities exist for you in a different market, location, or country?** Relatively few people are willing to relocate for their job, yet companies are hungry for workers who have experience across multiple markets.
- **What entrenched problems does your organization face?** How could you get involved in helping solve them?

As an idea for your next role takes shape, consider how you'd implement this change. Who would do your current work? What skills could you acquire to make this an easier sell to the company? Brainstorm about in-house, off-site, or virtual seminars and workshops you could attend, and figure out how participating in those programs would fit in with your current responsibilities.

When you're ready to pitch, pick the person who has the best mix of power and credibility to make your proposal a reality *and* with whom you have the best relationship. Your direct manager, mentor, or sponsor is a good target. Be clear about the benefit of your expanded or new role to the organization. Explain why you think you're best suited for the work, with detail about your competencies and your track record. Lay out how the transition would work, including a timeline for handing off your current role or subset of responsibilities and securing early wins in the new one.

Step 4: Pursue incremental opportunities

Don't be discouraged if the company doesn't immediately embrace your idea. You should be prepared to negotiate for an incremental, temporary, or transitional career move, like:

- **Growing in place.** Can you make changes to your current role and gradually add desired responsibilities or scope? If even this step meets resistance, consider starting a small project on your own. You might have better luck petitioning your company later if you can bring concrete results to the table.
- **A cross-functional team.** Can you partner with workers from different departments to bring your idea to fruition? This option helps you expand your networks and gain insight on other career paths.
- **Job rotation.** Does your company offer special assignments or rotational roles?
- **In-house internship.** Could you forge an agreement to intern under a supervisor to learn a new role?

Step 5: Look elsewhere

If you don't find an opportunity at your organization, it might be time to consider whether you need to look elsewhere. Searching for a position at a new company makes sense when:

- Your core interests don't match what your employer can offer.
- Market volatility has made your employment precarious.
- Your job is meant to be done for a short time and doesn't have a viable career path.
- Your organization isn't a good cultural fit for you and your preferences.

Use your network to research job opportunities, schedule informational interviews with leaders in the industry, and connect with decision makers. Reach out to mentors who are outside your workplace. And when you find an opportunity you want to pursue, enlist someone to introduce you (via email or a phone call) to the relevant hiring manager. In some fields, jobs posted online garner hundreds of résumés. A personal introduction and note of recommendation can distinguish you as someone an organization should interview. If you don't have a connection, put the request out to your network. See if someone you know can make an introduction to a person within the organization you are interested in.

When looking for a job outside your organization, keep these tips in mind: First, don't be disrespectful when talking about your current company. Second, don't use company time to pursue other opportunities. Use vacation or after-hours time for your research and interviews. Third, plan to provide sufficient notice to your current employer and leave as graciously as possible to avoid burning bridges.

Feedback from your boss and your team

The people who work with you directly can also play a role in your growth. They know more about how you work than anyone else, and they have unique perspectives on both your strengths and your weaknesses.

Receiving feedback can be inherently stressful, setting off your insecurity, fear, and anxiety. This information is important to hear, but its emotional impact can be overpowering. As research shows, that's because we listen more closely to negative information than to positive information, and remember it more vividly. So it's easy to become fixated on our deficiencies, while neglecting our strengths.

To learn from your immediate coworkers, you'll need to practice hearing and using criticism in positive ways. And you must also learn to spend as much time considering your strengths as your weaknesses.

Asking for and using criticism

One of the best ways to receive genuine, real-time feedback is to ask for it. Make this a part of your normal routine. At the end of a group meeting, when you're closing out a coaching session with an employee, or when you're driving back from the airport with a colleague after a business trip, ask this question: "Do you have any feedback for me about how that went, and how I could do better next time?"

Whether people—especially your employees—actually take you up on those questions will depend on how you react to even the first whiff of criticism. Does your response teach them to stay silent from now on? Or do you reward their honesty with respect, attention, and gratitude?

Criticism is easier to receive when you're aware and in control of your own emotional reactions. Executive coach and Stanford Graduate School of Business lecturer Ed Batista recommends that when you hear the words, "Don't take this personally, but . . .," you stop and recognize three elements of the conversation:

- **Your threat response.** Your brain is following age-old neurological and physiological patterns. Acknowledge that you're being triggered and remind yourself that your *perception* of threat doesn't mean you are actually under attack.
- **The power dynamic.** We become extremely sensitive to status during these conversations, and it's tempting to project a lot of negative motivations onto the other person. Is he lording his power over you or trying to assert supremacy? Is she trying to undermine your authority? Acknowledge your fears and choose to make the generous assumption: "This feels bad for me, but I think they're trying to help."
- **Your agency.** If you're feeling ambushed or blindsided, you might freeze up. It might not seem like it, but you *do* have a choice about whether you participate. Ask yourself, "Do I need to step out right

now? Or can I continue to hold this conversation?” Giving yourself the option to leave may actually settle your emotions.

One of the best ways to assimilate feedback as it’s being shared with you is to listen actively and probe for more insight: “Tell me more.” “I’m not sure I knew that about myself. Help me understand what you’re seeing.” Asking for more information takes you out of a personally defensive posture and puts you back in the inquisitive, curious mindset that is the hallmark of great leaders.

Over the long term, you can make these experiences easier by deepening your relationship with the feedback givers. When it’s time to talk about more difficult topics, you’ll feel safer and more curious about their input. You’ll also be able to relate the negative information to the bigger picture; your sense of purpose and your plans for growth.

Know your strengths

Not all feedback needs to be negative. When you reach out to your colleagues to collect their constructive criticism, you should also engage with them on your strengths. The “Reflected Best Self” exercise, created through the University of Michigan’s Center for Positive Organizations, can structure this process. Your goal here is to compose their experiences (and your own) into a unified vision of your best self to measure future decisions and actions.

Start by picking a wide range of people: family members and friends, past and present colleagues, teachers, mentors, and so on. Ask them to describe your strengths and to share specific stories about when they’ve witnessed those traits.

Then organize all the material you collected and search for common themes. Group examples by theme and then take a stab at explaining who you are or how you behave when you live up to those ideals. Exhibit 8-1 shows an example of one row of a table you can create listing your strengths; each row would highlight examples of a different theme.

Once you’ve compiled these memories and themes, turn the bullet points into prose. Use the feedback and your own observations to write

EXHIBIT 8-1

Reflected best self—sample row

Common theme	Examples given	Possible interpretation
Curiosity and perseverance	• I gave up my promising career in the military to get my MBA. • I investigated and solved a security breach through an innovative approach.	I'm at my best when I'm meeting new challenges. I take risks and persevere despite obstacles.

Source: Adapted from Laura Morgan Roberts, Gretchen Spreitzer, Jane E. Dutton, Robert E. Quinn, Emily Heaphy, and Brianna Barker, "How to Play to Your Strengths," *Harvard Business Review*, January 2005.

a two- to four-paragraph description of your best self. Try opening with these phrases:

- “When I’m at my best, I . . .”
- “I enjoy . . .”
- “Others rely on me to . . .”
- “My best work is . . .”
- “I feel most like myself when . . .”
- “I thrive when . . .”

Now reread what you’ve written: Where is your current role best aligned with the self-portrait you just created? Where are the biggest sources of friction? What elements of your role do you have the power to alter—the composition of your team, the way you do your work or spend your time?

Finally, design some small experiments to bring your job into better alignment with what you’ve learned or put yourself in the best possible position to succeed. Instead of initiating a grand overhaul that requires approval from higher-ups, try making two or three targeted adjustments at a time. For example, if you’re at your best when you’re collaborating with others, look for areas of overlap with your peers in other units and start a regular series of meetings about how you could better work together.

Engaging with feedback from your boss and employees will advance your thinking about the kind of leader you want to be. Building around your strengths and mitigating or improving in areas of weakness will allow you to develop into a stronger leader. It also supports your career development process over time, throughout your career.

In order to supervise others well, you must invest in your own competencies—influence, communication, personal productivity, and self-development. To connect with and advocate for your employees, you must develop personal power and an authentic voice. And to help them organize their work, you must understand how to prioritize your time and projects. These skills make you a stronger contributor in the organization, but as a manager, they also deeply affect the overall functioning of your team.

Recap

- The first step in your self-development is articulating your career *purpose*: What do you want out of your work, and what do you want to accomplish?
- Search for development opportunities by first examining the options available in your workplace.
- Feedback from those you work with can help you understand where to grow—as well as your areas of strength.

Action items

To define your career purpose:

- ☐ Complete the “Find your purpose” questionnaire at the beginning of this chapter.

- ☐ Reformulate the answers to your questions into a statement: “My purpose is . . .”
- ☐ Refine your statement, sharing it with friends, family, and colleagues to get their input.

To find opportunities within your organization:

- ☐ Take advantage of formal development opportunities your company offers. Talk to your boss and to the HR department to find out what’s available.
- ☐ Conduct informational interviews with internal leaders about any functions that interest you. Use your contacts within the company to set up meetings and come prepared with good questions and great manners.
- ☐ If no existing opportunities catch your fancy, propose the job you *want* to do. Figure out where there’s an unmet need or untapped opportunity in your company, and how your current team will survive your transition.
- ☐ If you can’t move to a totally new role, pursue incremental opportunities in your current position, such as joining a cross-functional team.
- ☐ If you truly see no chances for growth in your current organization, use your network to find opportunity elsewhere. Exit as graciously as possible.

Solicit feedback from your boss and your team:

- ☐ Ask for feedback as often as possible—at the end of a meeting or after a presentation—from your colleagues as well as those above you in the organization.
- ☐ When you receive criticism, be prepared for completely natural emotional responses that may pop up. If the feedback feels bad or wrong, why? What happens if you make a more generous set of assumptions about where the other person is coming from?

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- ☐ If you start to feel overwhelmed by negative feedback, excuse yourself from the conversation and don't return until you've regained your equilibrium.
- ☐ Also use the "Reflected Best Self" exercise to ask for positive feedback and use it to triangulate a picture of who you are at your best. Use that information to reverse-engineer your job: how would it work for your best self?